MEDIEVAL FOOT SOLDIERS

Medieval knights tended to despise foot soldiers as a lowborn rabble. Their presence on the battlefield was a necessity, but it was a regrettable one. On many occasions, however, infantry armed with pikes, clubs, and other simple weapons proved their effectiveness against armoured cavalry when resolute and properly organized. Armed with missile weapons, whether with longbows, crossbows, or early forms of cannon, foot soldiers could more easily subvert the social order. Knights especially resented these men who fought at a distance, an action they considered not only cowardly, but unfair, at least when used against them. In general no quarter was given to foot soldiers when they were taken prisoner – after all, they were not in a position to pay a ransom.

FLEMISH FOOT SOLDIER

In 1302 France sent a substantial army, including a large body of knights, to crush a rebellion in Flanders. The Flemish fielded a force composed almost entirely of foot soldiers. They were a well-drilled urban artisan militia, led by a small number of noblemen. Their distinctive arm was the "goedendag", a long pole with a spearhead at one end and a mace head at the other. At Courtrai on 11 July, they took up a position on ground criss-crossed by streams, to which they added ditches of their own. This gave them some protection from the French cavalry charge, which they brought to a halt by stubbornly holding their lines. Flemish soldiers then surrounded and picked off the stalled knights one by one.



Battle of Courtrai
Although the armour and weapons of the Flemish are not accurately portrayed in this painting, it shows how they halted the knights and methodically unhorsed and killed them.

SCOTTISH SCHILTRON

In its war against England in the 13th and 14th centuries, the core of Scotland's forces were the infantry schiltrons. The schiltron was a phalanx-like formation of pikemen standing shoulder-to-shoulder, often organized in a circle. The majority of the foot soldiers were levies who, depending on their wealth, were expected to turn up either simply with a pike, or with additional equipment such as a sword, helmet, quilted body armour, and protective gloves. The armoured men were placed in the front rows. Bristling with pikes, the schiltron was a highly effective defensive formation against a cavalry charge, but could also be used offensively as it was at Bannockburn in 1314. But in their packed formation the Scottish infantry were vulnerable to the arrows of the English king's longbowmen.

HUSSITE SOLDIER



Hussites were the radical followers of a strict form of Christianity in 15th-century Bohemia. Declared heretical by the papacy, they had to defend themselves against a crusade. Under the leadership of Czech squire Jan Žižka, a band of peasant farmers, artisans, and traders was turned into a disciplined force, obeying written statutes that laid down rules for punishments, camp life, and the division of booty. United by their beliefs, the Hussites marched to battle singing hymns. They devised innovative tactics, employing new and old weapons side by side. Many of their soldiers were armed with simple flails or pole arms, and they employed mounted crossbowmen. But they also built battle wagons, reinforced with iron, in which they installed cannons and men with firearms. These could be used as mobile fire platforms, driving in columns through enemy lines. The Hussites' most famous victory was at Kutná Hora in 1421.

Hussite encampment
The Hussites formed defensive encampments by circling their wagons. Defended by cannons, arquebuses, and crossbows, these laagers almost invariably thwarted any attackers.

"YE WHO ARE WARRIORS OF GOD AND OF HIS LAW, PRAY TO GOD FOR HELP..."

HUSSITE BATTLE SONG